Myanmar (Burma)

Forming the eastern shores of the Bay of Bengal and the Andaman Sea in southeast Asia, Myanmar suffers from isolation, political repression, and ethnic conflict.

GEOGRAPHY

The fertile Irrawaddy basin lies at the center. Mountains to the west, Shan plateau to the east. Tropical rainforest covers much of the land.

CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot summers, with high humidity, and warm winters.

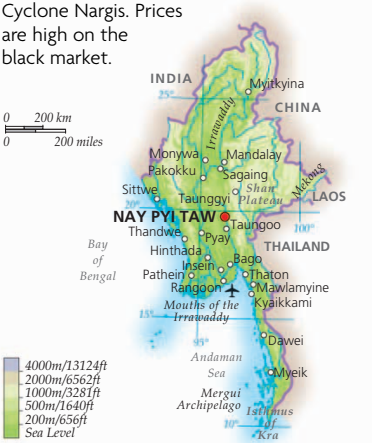
PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The military, in power since 1962, rules Myanmar with little regard to human rights. Opposition is not tolerated. The National League for Democracy won elections in 1990, but was kept from power. Its leader, Aung San Suu Kyi, is frequently detained. Minority groups maintain low-level guerrilla activity against the state.

INSIGHT: *Myanmar is one of the world's biggest teak exporters, though reserves are diminishing rapidly*

THE ECONOMY

Corrupt, mismanaged, subject to sanctions – but gas, teak, and gems are exported. Illicit opium production has fallen. Rice shortages in 2008 after Cyclone Nargis. Prices are high on the black market.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Union of Myanmar
DATE OF FORMATION: 1948
CAPITAL: Nay Pyi Taw
POPULATION: 50 million
TOTAL AREA: 261,969 sq. miles (678,500 sq. km)
DENSITY: 197 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Burmese*, Shan, Karen, Rakhine, Chin, Yangbye, Kachin, Mon
RELIGIONS: Buddhist 87%, Christian 6%, Muslim 4%, other 2%, Hindu 1%
ETHNIC MIX: Burman 68%, other 13%, Shan 9%, Karen 6%, Rakhine 4%
GOVERNMENT: Military-based regime
CURRENCY: Kyat = 100 pyas